



FROM THE BRINK

India has endured a lean year in Test cricket, but the fifth morning at The Oval delivered a reminder of why the format still produces its sharpest theatre.

England, chasing 374, had batted with authority to put itself firmly in control. Late strikes on the fourth evening, however, transformed a routine pursuit into a nervy finish. On the final morning, England needed 35 runs. India needed four wickets and had to do so without Jasprit Bumrah. There was already a sense of lingering grievance. India had fallen 23 runs short at Lord's, and in this Test, Harry Brook had survived on 19 after Mohammed Siraj caught him on the fine leg boundary, but inadvertently stepped over the rope. The stage was set, not for redemption by sentiment, but for execution with the old ball.

With reverse swing finally on offer, Siraj struck first, removing Jamie Smith and Jamie Overton with full, attacking lengths. Prasidh Krishna chipped in by knocking over Josh Tongue, leaving England suddenly reliant on Gus Atkinson and a clearly limited Chris Woakes.

England's recent history of improbable chases meant the threat lingered. Atkinson dragged it within seven runs, refusing to let the moment slip quietly.

Siraj ended it decisively. A full delivery tailed in, beat Atkinson, and uprooted the off stump. India had stolen victory from the brink, sealing a tense win and squaring the series 2-2.